region of central diplomatic importance. Indeed, the George W. Bush administration viewed improved relations with India as so important that it devised a deal to provide the Indians with civilian nuclear fuel and technology, despite India's refusal to sign the 1968 Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT).[5] Pakistan, for its part, has been at the center of the global antiterrorism campaign since the attacks of September 11, 2001.[6] Developments in Pakistan will have especially serious implications for coalition efforts to rout the Taliban from Afghanistan and stabilize that country. Given these economic, demographic, strategic, and diplomatic factors, the international community has a significant stake in stability in the South Asian region.

Unfortunately, the subcontinent's history has been far from stable. Independent India and Pakistan emerged out of a bloody partition that left hundreds of thousands dead and millions displaced. The two countries then endured decades of hostility, including four wars and an ongoing conflict in Kashmir between Indian security forces and Pakistan-backed insurgents. Such a violent relationship, when combined with nuclear weapons, could prove to be a combustible mix. This danger makes proliferation's impact on the region an even more urgent subject for study.

Finally, South Asia's experience with nuclear weapons may offer lessons that are applicable well beyond the region. Current analyses of nuclear proliferation's likely effects are based largely on arguments drawn from Cold War history. But future proliferators such as North Korea or Iran may not closely resemble the United States or the Soviet Union. Indeed, they may have more in common with countries like India and Pakistan than with the two superpowers. If this is the case, then a careful study of nuclear weapons' impact on South Asia can help us anticipate their likely effects on future proliferators elsewhere around the globe. Although we do not explicitly discuss states such as Iran and North Korea, the basic principles underlying our arguments can be applied to them.

This book assesses nuclear weapons' impact on the South Asian security environment during three time periods: South Asia's nuclear past, spanning from the late 1980s through 2002; the nuclear present from 2002 through 2007; and the nuclear future, from 2008